Report on "Matrix Theory Reloaded: A BPS Road to Holography"

Blair, Lahnsteiner, Obers, Yan

1. Principal achievement

The paper offers a single organising principle for three subjects that are usually treated separately: matrix theories, holography, and non-Lorentzian string/M-theory. The key observation is that the decoupling limits giving matrix theories on Dp-branes (the "MpT" limits) are *BPS* limits. Applied to the curved brane background, the same limit automatically produces the Maldacena near-horizon limit. When uplifted to M-theory, each such limit is a DLCQ. This leads to the conjecture that holography is a DLCQ^n/DLCQ^m correspondence ($m > n$). In this language AdS$_5$/CFT$_4$ is DLCQ^0/DLCQ^1, D1–D5 gives an example with $m > n + 1$, and applying two limits in sequence gives new dualities with non-Lorentzian bulks. A second, more concrete result comes from reading off how the brane actions depend on the decoupling parameter $\lambda = \omega^{-2}$. This gives explicit $T\bar{T}$-like flow equations for the Dp-brane DBI action and the M2-brane. The three-dimensional M2 flow, $\partial_\lambda \mathcal{L} = \frac{1}{4}\sqrt{-\det \tau}\,[\mathrm{tr}\,\mathcal{T}^2 - (\mathrm{tr}\,\mathcal{T})^2 + 2\lambda \det \mathcal{T}]$, is especially simple. In the bulk, undoing the near-horizon limit then appears as a deformation that generates the brane geometry out of the flat non-Lorentzian geometry at asymptotic infinity. This is a fresh view of why the bulk exists.

2. Principal drawback

The central conjecture is mostly a reorganisation of known dualities and is not yet a predictive statement. The paper does not give a dynamical test that would separate DLCQ^n/DLCQ^m from the standard near-horizon argument. The new non-Lorentzian holographic examples are the least secure part. Their bulk geometries come from an ad hoc extra rescaling of the harmonic function, which amounts to rescaling N, and its physical meaning is unclear. The authors also say openly that they have not checked that these geometries solve the equations of motion and torsional constraints of MpT supergravity. That theory has not itself been formulated, and the symmetries, charges and supersymmetry of the solutions have not been worked out. The geometric picture at asymptotic infinity has further weak points. Quantum corrections may dominate there, the dilaton runs to strong coupling for $p > 3$, and the non-Lorentzian structure may depend on the choice of coordinates. Finally, the $T\bar{T}$ flows are derived only for bosonic, abelian actions, while the claimed link to matrix theory needs the non-abelian, supersymmetric case.

3. Most worthwhile follow-up

Balancing feasibility and impact, I recommend *extending the p-brane $T\bar{T}$ flow equations to the non-abelian (and ideally supersymmetric) case and testing them on matrix theory.* A concrete programme:

- Apply the flow, e.g. the M2 equation or its Dp analogue, to U(N) SYM as the initial condition. Solve it order by order in λ. Compare the result with the known α' expansion of the non-abelian DBI action: the symmetrised trace at F^4, and the known commutator ambiguities at F^6 and beyond.
- Use the MpT parametrisation of Myers' action as a target, and check whether the flow fixes the ordering ambiguities.
- For $p = 2$, apply the flow to BLG/ABJM to look for an M-theoretic non-abelian "DBI" endpoint.

This is feasible because it is a well-posed classical field-theory computation that builds directly on equations the paper has already derived. The F^4 term gives an immediate check. The potential impact is large. A successful flow would turn the paper's main conjecture into something testable: undoing the DLCQ/near-horizon limit would become a solvable deformation of matrix theory, and it might fix the long-standing non-abelian DBI ordering problem. If the flow fails to reproduce the F^4 term, that would be equally informative about how far the framework can be trusted. A more ambitious but riskier alternative is to formulate MpT supergravity and verify the non-Lorentzian bulk solutions.